



Jump off from a carrier

off and land from international airports, cramped dirt strips, and—hold your breath—an aircraft carrier! The environment settings are detailed, and you can choose the time, cloud cover, wind conditions, and more. Whether on the ground or in the air, you have several views to choose from, both inside and outside the aircraft.

You can play *Flight Gear* using either keyboard or joystick. Remember that if you're new to flight simu-

lations, you might be overwhelmed by the plethora of key combinations—but only initially.

Ground scenery is not as detailed as in *Microsoft Flight Simulator*. This lack of detail works to your advantage, really: you don't have to watch the plane suspended in mid-air as the ground maps continue loading. The sound, comprising ATC traffic and static is as realistic as can be, although it must be said that if you crash, the radio will not let you die in peace.

Another unique feature in this game is sloped runways—try landing on them and see gravity in action. You can fly in formation with other players and download sceneries, runways, and planes from the homepage.

Rating: 6/10

TORCS (The Open Racing Car Simulator)

<http://www.torcs.sourceforge.net>

A well-known free and open source racing simulator that's been around for years, each and every aspect of TORCS' gameplay can be configured. It's also surprisingly CPU-light.

The default package is limited in terms of tracks and cars—but more resources are available on the Web. To get the most out of TORCS, you'll need to visit sites and download cars, tracks, and scenes. There's a list of related sites at the homepage. The packaged tracks include dirt tracks and roadways. Most of the cars that come with the default installation are, looks-wise, the NASCAR rally type.

There seem to be a few bugs; the number of competitors you select in the beginning might not be how many you end up racing against! Then, the AI-powered cars in front of you often look like they're spitting flames from the

exhaust à la *The Fast and the Furious*, though you might call this a feature that makes the cars look cool. In-game graphics like skid marks are pretty realistic, and what is more gratifying is that unlike in most other games, the other cars, too, skid uncontrollably along tight corners.

This game can be played online: there's a World Endurance Championship where players design their own cars and race them.

Rating: 6.5/10



Straight road ahead—fancy burning some rubber?

Rune

<http://www.runegames.com>

Norse mythology has been one of the most favourite themes in popular fiction. In case you didn't know, several themes in *Lord of the Rings* come from Norse-land. It's been affecting games, too, for a long time; themes from Norse mythology—Valhalla, Odin the King of the Gods, The End of the World, and such—have been a recurring feature of many games, especially in the fantasy RPG genre, both online as well as offline. There has also been the occasional title in the RTS genre—recall *Age of Mythology*. *Rune*, though, is a bit like a square peg in a round hole. It is a first-person hack-and-slash game that combines elements of fantasy RPG and FPS. Released for Windows, it has been ported to Linux by Loki Software.

Rune follows the adventures of Ragnor, a keen young warrior who journeys across the worlds of the un-dead to mountainous

regions in order to prevent the evil god Loki from unleashing Ragnarok—the end of the world. Sound interesting enough already? He fight monsters, goblins, dwarves, and other races in his desperate fight to save Midgard, the world of men. Ultimately—and this has something to do with a pond, but we won't reveal more than that—you get the powers of Loki's fearsome monsters. At that crossroads, it's up to



Hackin' and Slashin'